

CHAPTER 4

British Rule in Uttarakhand (1815–1947)

4.1 ARRIVAL & TERRITORIAL DIVISION (1815)

Following the defeat of the Gorkhas and the Treaty of Sugauli (1815), the British East India Company took control of the region. The territory was divided into two parts: British Kumaon and Garhwal (east of the Alaknanda River) came under direct British rule and was included in the Kumaon Commissionerate, while the western trans-Alaknanda region (excluding Dehradun and Rawain) was handed to the Parmar King Sudarshan Shah as the Tehri Riyasat (Princely State). The Alaknanda River thus served as the natural boundary between British territory and the Tehri Princely State.

The initial period of British rule (1815–1857) was characterized as a time of subdued governance, peace, and dynamism — a stark contrast to the brutal Gorkha era, which had conditioned the traumatized local population to perceive British administration as liberal and reformist.

4.2 MAJOR BRITISH COMMISSIONERS

Commissioner	Tenure	Key Title / Epithet	Major Contributions
Edward Gardner	1815–1816	First Commissioner of British Kumaon	Appointed May 3, 1815; initiated first land settlement in Kumaon; started postal service between Almora and Srinagar
G.W. Traill	1816–1835	Father of Revenue Police System	"Na Vakeel, Na Daleel, Na Appeal"; created 9 Patwari posts (1819); Double Lock System (1824); Mule Army (1822); Assi Sala Settlement (1823); Almora Jail (1816); Pauri Jail (1821); Thapla land reservation (1826)
J.H. Batten	1848–1856	—	Shifted HQ from Almora to Nainital (Oct 1855); 8th Settlement (Bees Sala); Upper Ganges Canal completed (1854)
Sir Henry Ramsay	1856–1884	'Uncrowned King of Kumaon'	Golden Age of British rule; codified Revenue Police (1874); abolished forest contract system (1858); managed 1857 revolt; Ramsay Collegiate School (1871); Beckett's scientific settlement
K.L. Mehta	1947–48	First & only Indian Commissioner	Last Commissioner of Kumaon Commissionerate

4.3 COMMISSIONER G.W. TRAILL — DETAILED PROFILE

G.W. Traill was the man who built the administrative DNA of British Uttarakhand. His judicial policy was characteristically iron-fisted, encapsulated in the phrase *"Na Vakeel, Na Daleel, Na Appeal"* (No lawyer, no argument, no appeal).

In 1819, Traill created the Revenue Police system by establishing nine posts of Patwari — officials responsible for revenue collection, land records, and police powers simultaneously. In 1824, he introduced the Double Lock System for treasury security, whereby one key was held by the Collector and another by the Treasurer. To address the exploitative Coolie Begar system, he established the 'Mule Army' (Khachchar Sena) in 1822 to transport goods, reducing the burden on forced labourers.

🔗 4.7 BRITISH FOREST MANAGEMENT — FOUR PHASES

🔗 PHASE 1: Early Exploitation & Contract System (1815–1858)

In 1818, Traill leased the Shivalik and Bhabar forests to contractors through the Kath-Bamboo Mahals system. His 1826 Thapla Land Reservation, which reserved land for government use and banned Sal tree felling, represented the first government-controlled forests. The demand for wooden railway sleepers, beginning with the railway boom of 1853, placed enormous pressure on the region's forests. Between 1853 and 1861, Frederick Wilson — known as 'Pahari Wilson' — operated as a British timber merchant who ruthlessly felled forests and floated timber down the Alaknanda and Bhagirathi rivers. The period from 1855 to 1861 marked the absolute peak of forest destruction in Uttarakhand.

🔗 PHASE 2: Scientific Management & Restrictive Laws (1858–1911)

Henry Ramsay's 1858 abolition of the contractor system marked a turning point. He initiated scientific management practices including tree marking, fire protection, and planned plantation. In 1864, the Forest Department was formally created under the German expert Dietrich Brandis, appointed as the first Inspector General of Forests. The First Forest Act followed in 1865, passed on Brandis's advice. A Forest School was established in Dehradun in 1878, also on Brandis's recommendation, and was renamed the Imperial Forest School in 1884.

In 1893, the Benap Notification declared all Benap (unmeasured) land as protected forests. The First Forest Policy of 1894 made hunting of wild animals and fishing strictly illegal. The Forest School was upgraded to the Imperial Forest Research Institute in 1906. Between 1911 and 1917, the Stiffe and Nelson Settlement declared an additional 3,311 square miles as reserved forests, completely stripping the local population of ancestral rights.

🔗 PHASE 3: Forest Rebellions — Public Backlash (1904–1930)

The restrictive forest policies provoked determined public resistance. The Khas Patti (Kunjdi Van) Movement of 1904–1906 saw villagers revolting against Conservator Keshavanand for reserving forests around the Chandrabadni temple in Tehri. In 1921, widespread protest fires were set in reserved forests. Durga Devi of Someshwar became the first woman arrested in the movement, imprisoned for one month for burning Thakalodi forests, while Mohan Singh Mehta was the first man arrested from Kumaon.

The most tragic episode was the Tiladi (Rawain) Massacre of May 30, 1930. The Tehri king's Diwan, Chakradhar Juyal, ordered firing on unarmed farmers gathered at Tiladi ground on the banks of the Yamuna. This event has been called the "Jallianwala Bagh of Uttarakhand," and May 30 is observed as Martyr's Day.

🔗 PHASE 4: Resolution & Forest Panchayats (1921–1931)

On April 13, 1921, a Forest Grievances Committee was convened under Kumaon Commissioner Percy Wyndham. The committee acknowledged villagers' suffering due to rigid "scientific forestry" and recommended returning rights, lifting bans on bamboo and grazing, and allowing forest rights up to half a mile from each village.

These recommendations culminated in the Forest Panchayat Act of 1931, which established Van Panchayats and divided forests into Reserved, Protected, and Village categories. The Van Panchayat system uniquely empowers local communities in Uttarakhand to manage forests — it continues to this day and is studied globally as a model of community forest governance.

🔗 4.8 ECONOMY UNDER BRITISH RULE

🔗 Revenue Sources

The British administration derived revenue from three principal sources: land revenue collected through eleven settlements: